Paying close attention to the pre-negotiation process, including the process of preparation, agenda-setting, venue and perception management can be crucial for success in any negotiation with China. The internal preparation should presume that China's intention will be to place the Indian interlocutor in the position of a supplicant or on the back foot before the talks begin. This pitfall may be avoided by equal preparation on the Indian side. The Indian interlocutor must have full knowledge of facts, know his own bottom line, avoid time deadlines and, as Richard H. Solomon puts it, demonstrate competence and control over the negotiating process.

The Chinese Negotiator

Chinese negotiators follow a pattern that was set by Premier Zhou Enlai who was both Premier and Foreign Minister for many years. Changes have occurred in both style and substance since, but a thread of continuity continues to run through the process. The simple thumb rule in any negotiation is that only the Chinese head of delegation shall speak unless she or he asks another delegation member to elaborate on a point or present an idea. The rest of the delegation is there to provide inputs and to take notes. The process of negotiation is theatrical; the head of delegation will talk in lofty terms and imbue each word and gesture with meaning and purpose like an actor or player in a drama. The Chinese negotiator will also insert a Chinese proverb or two; they know that foreigners are impressed by Chinese proverbs such as 'When we drink the water we should not forget who dug the well', or, as in the case of India–China relations, the proverb 'The one who tied the bell on the tiger's neck should untie it'. It is nonetheless important to pay attention to the choice of words by the Chinese side because these are part of an internal code that allows the entire network